

IILM Institute of Higher Education.

It is surprising that despite having set up an India Research Center in Mumbai way back in March 2008 and having done interesting work over the last two decades, Harvard Business School (HBS) has not set up a full-fledged India campus. The University of Chicago Booth's relationship with India goes back to 1913, when Nobel Prize winner Rabindranath Tagore addressed their US campus. Similarly, in 1936, University of Chicago alumnus Clifford Manshardt, initiated the proposal to set up a school for professional social work in Mumbai. That led to the Dorabji Tata School of Social Work which was set up at Nagpada Neighbourhood House with Manshardt as its first Director. That institution later evolved to become the famed Tata Institute of Social Sciences, which today has four campuses, nine schools, 33 centres, and 10 research facilities across India.

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Several US business schools have collaborations with Indian business schools at various levels, ranging from twinning programmes, joint certifications, and partnerships. Kellogg School of Management, Wharton (Business) School, and Fletcher School at Tufts University are three US institutions that are associate schools of the Indian School of Business (ISB). Through these associations, they brought global insights to ISB's Bharti Institute of Public Policy and Max Institute of Healthcare. Ashoka University recently launched a special round of admissions for those students who have offer letters from American universities but were not able to join their colleges. Sanjeev Bikhchandani, one of the co-founders of Ashoka University, announced on his X handle, "This special round has been announced to support students and families seeking academic continuity and a world-class education, as they navigate increasing concerns around safety, visa delays, and shifting global policies."

BETTING ON INDIA

Why institutions like Harvard University might consider scaling up India presence

▶ India allowed foreign universities to set up campuses in India way back in 2020 through the New Education Policy. The response has been lukewarm

▶ Ashoka University recently launched a special round of admissions for those students who have offer letters from US universities but were not able to join their colleges

▶ Many of the storied US universities like Harvard, Wharton, Kellogg, Columbia, University of Chicago Booth, and Yale had opened India centres for activities ranging from research, case study development, to collaborations and alumni outreach, all of them had stopped short of setting up full-fledged campuses

▶ It is estimated that about 300,000 Indian students in the US contribute about \$8 billion annually to the US economy

▶ There have been Indian success stories like that of Eruditus Executive Education, which has tie-ups with about 80 global B-schools

SOURCE: REPORTS

It is estimated that about 300,000 Indian students in the US contribute about \$8 billion annually to the US economy. In fact, as recent as February 2025, Prime Minister Narendra Modi and President Trump issued a joint statement to strengthen India-US academic ties, including the setting up of India campuses.

It was implied that higher education partnerships between the countries would be mutually beneficial. Despite all the above, leading US business schools have had a wait-and-watch attitude to set up full-fledged operations in India. Will that change now? A clear answer is difficult to come by.

Since last year, there has been a mild rush from universities outside the US to set up campuses in India. These include about 15 universities, ranging from the UK's University of Southampton and University of Liverpool, and Deakin University from Australia. While they are lesser-known institutions than their US counterparts, they will have a head start and perhaps be more

price-competitive in a mass education market like India. Additionally, there have been Indian success stories like that of Eruditus Executive Education, which has tie-ups with about 80 business schools from across the world, including the top US colleges like Columbia Business School and Kellogg, where executive education is facilitated online and offline for Indian business leaders. Francois Therin, deputy Vice Chancellor (research and enterprise) at the University of Cyberjaya in Malaysia, in a recent article in Times Higher Education, argues that China has taken a lead in inviting foreign universities to set up campuses in that country.

The capacities are also large, ranging from 10,000 to 25,000 students at a time in one of the local campuses of the University of Nottingham and Liverpool.

Education consultants are helping institutions from outside set up and scale operations in India and overseas.

Will the Harvard's of the world finally arrive in India? **BT**